

WordPress

Theme Contribution Guide

Section A

Core Theme Contribution

Bundled themes, developer workflow, GitHub PRs

Section B

Community Theme Reviews

Review checklist, workflow, trac tickets

Section C

Block Theme Development

theme.json, templates, patterns, Ipsum

About This Guide

This guide was created for WordCamp contributors. It covers everything you need to get started with contributing to WordPress themes — from core bundled themes, to reviewing community themes, to building your own block theme from scratch.

Handbook

make.wordpress.org/themes/handbook/

Slack — #themes

make.wordpress.org/chat/

Theme Trac

themes.trac.wordpress.org/report/2

Developer Handbook

developer.wordpress.org/themes/

Theme Table Lead

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Happy contributing to WordPress!

Section A

Core Theme Contribution

Contributing to WordPress Bundled Default Themes

Overview: What Are Bundled Themes?

Bundled themes (e.g. Twenty Twenty-Four, Twenty Twenty-Five) are the current and previous default themes included when you install WordPress. A new default theme is usually included in the last major release of the year. The design is selected and approved by project lead Matt Mullenweg before development starts.

For the past 3+ years, the development of the default theme has been open to all contributors.

Ways to Contribute to the Default Theme

Source: [Contributing to Bundled Themes — Handbook](#)

1. **Suggest Features** — Submit feature ideas as early in the release cycle as possible. Submit suggestions via GitHub issues or the #themes Slack channel.
2. **Test and Report Issues** — The earlier testing starts, the fewer bugs make it into the final release. Accessibility testing should be prioritized. Report issues by opening tickets in Core Trac.
3. **Contribute Code** — Help develop new features and fix reported issues. You can also review pull requests and audit existing code.
4. **Write Copy and Documentation** — Every theme needs a theme description. Use sentence casing (not title case) and keep text consistent with previous default themes.

Step-by-Step Developer Workflow

1. Find a Bug or Feature Ticket

- **Core Trac:** core.trac.wordpress.org
- **Bundled Theme tickets:** [core.trac.wordpress.org — Bundled Theme component](#)
- Before opening a new issue, search to make sure it is not already reported.
- Post a comment on the ticket to state that you are working on it.

2. Submit a Pull Request (PR) via GitHub

```
git checkout -b fix/theme-issue-description
git add .
git commit -m "Fix: describe your change clearly"
git push origin fix/theme-issue-description
```

⚠ Crucial for Props: In your PR description, write Fixes #TRAC_TICKET_NUMBER or include the full Trac ticket link. Also list the WordPress.org usernames of all contributors who should receive props/credit.

Reference: [Contributing to Bundled Themes — Theme Handbook](#)

3. For Beta Releases

- Add your patch or pull request to WordPress trunk.
- For Release Candidates: changes require sign-off from two committers. Only bug fixes accepted.

Maintaining Existing Bundled Themes

- Opening issues in Core Trac when you find problems.
- **Triage:** Help move tickets closer to being fixed or closed. See → [Themes Triage Guide](#)
- Submitting fixes via GitHub pull requests or Trac patches.

Important Notes

Accessibility Requirements

The default theme must be accessibility-ready and aim to comply with WCAG 2.2 AA.

[Accessibility-Ready Theme Requirements](#)

Key Resources — Section A

- [Contributing to Bundled Themes — Handbook](#)
- [WordPress Core Trac — Bundled Theme Component](#)
- [wordpress-develop — GitHub](#)
- [WordPress Theme Developer Handbook](#)
- [Accessibility-Ready Requirements](#)
- [Theme Triage Guide](#)
- [Release Cycle: Update Bundled Themes](#)

Section B

Community Theme Reviews

How to Review and Approve Themes for the WordPress.org Directory

What is a Theme Reviewer?

A theme reviewer is a volunteer who helps theme authors add their theme to the official WordPress.org theme directory. A reviewer installs and tests the theme, reviews the code, and checks for security issues. The reviewer also confirms that the theme is compatible with the GPL (General Public License) used by WordPress.

Who can become a reviewer? Anyone! You don't need to be an expert. Reviewing themes is a great way to learn more about theme development.

Source: [Become a Reviewer — make.wordpress.org](https://make.wordpress.org/themes/2015/06/01/become-a-reviewer/)

Preparations: Getting Started

- **Create a WordPress.org Account** — Register at
→ wordpress.org/support/register.php
- **Join the Making WordPress Slack** — Sign up with your WordPress.org account. Join the #themes channel.
→ make.wordpress.org/chat/
- **Subscribe to the Themes Blog** — Stay updated with team news and announcements.
→ make.wordpress.org/themes

Set Up Your Testing Environment

- **Install a Local WordPress Site** —
→ [Installing a Local Server — Handbook](#)
- **Enable WP_DEBUG** — Set WP_DEBUG to 'true' in your wp-config.php file.
→ [How to Set WP_DEBUG — Handbook](#)
- **Import Theme Unit Test Data** — Go to WP Admin > Tools > Import > WordPress and upload the theme-xml-test-data.xml file.
→ [WordPress Theme Test Data — GitHub](#)

Install Required & Optional Plugins

Required:

- **Theme Check** — wordpress.org/plugins/theme-check/

Optional but Recommended:

- **Query Monitor** — wordpress.org/plugins/query-monitor/
- **Debug Bar** — wordpress.org/plugins/debug-bar/
- **Theme Sniffer** — github.com/WPTT/theme-sniffer
- **WordPress Beta Tester** — wordpress.org/plugins/wordpress-beta-tester/

Learn the Theme Review Requirements

All themes submitted to the directory are reviewed against a strict set of requirements. Themes with 3 or more distinct issues may be closed as not-approved.

Full Required Checklist: make.wordpress.org/themes/handbook/review/required/

Key Required Areas:

1. **Licensing & Copyright:** Themes must be GPL (General Public License)-compatible. All code, images, and fonts must include license info.
2. **Privacy:** Any user data tracking must be disabled by default and opt-in only.
3. **Accessibility:** Must include skip links, keyboard navigation, and visible focus highlighting.
4. **Code Quality:** No PHP/JS errors, warnings, or notices. All untrusted data must be sanitized and escaped.
5. **Functionality:** No custom post types, custom blocks, shortcodes, or plugin-territory features.
6. **Plugins:** May only recommend plugins hosted on WordPress.org. No automatic installation.
7. **Naming:** Theme names must not include "WordPress", "Theme", or "Twenty*". No trademark violations.
8. **Internationalization:** All text strings must be translatable using gettext. Use the theme slug as text-domain.
9. **Files:** No hidden files, zip files, SQL dumps, or system files. No remote resource loading without user consent.
10. **Classic Themes:** Must include `wp_head()`, `body_class()`, `wp_footer()`, `wp_body_open()`, `post_class()`.
11. **Block Themes:** Must include `style.css`, `readme.txt`, `theme.json`, and `index.html` inside a `/templates/` folder.
12. **Settings & Onboarding:** Use `admin_notices` hook. No popups on activation. No demo imports.
13. **Credits & Links:** Only one front-facing credit link allowed. No obtrusive upselling.

style.css Required Headers: Theme Name, Author, Description, Version, Requires at least, Tested up to, Requires PHP, License, License URI, Text Domain

The Theme Review Workflow (Step-by-Step)

1. Find a Theme Ticket

- New Themes Queue: themes.trac.wordpress.org/report/2
- Themes assigned to you: themes.trac.wordpress.org/report/11
- Select the theme at the top of the list and leave a comment that you are starting the review.
- Or ask in the #themes Slack channel for a ticket to be assigned to you.

2. Do Your Review

- Run Theme Check scan.
- Visually inspect the site: responsive layout, navigation, comment styles, block display.
- Check Query Monitor for PHP errors, warnings, or notices.
- **Important:** Do NOT review design. Focus is on license and security only.

3. Write Your Ticket Response

- **Welcome:** Greet the author, especially if it's their first review.
- **Outcome:** State the result clearly at the top (Approved / Changes Required).
- **Required:** List all required items that must be fixed before approval.
- **Recommended:** List suggestions that won't block approval but are good practice.
- **Notes:** Add extra information, design observations (not blocking).
- **Next Steps:** Tell the author what happens next and what they should do.

[How to Write and Save the Review — Handbook](#)

4. Follow Up & Approve

- Do NOT close the ticket. Leave it open for the author's updates.
- Approve the theme only once it passes ALL requirements.
- After approval, an experienced reviewer will verify and add the theme to the directory.

Key Resources — Section B

- [Theme Review Handbook](#)
- [Required Theme Checklist](#)
- [Onboarding for New Reviewers](#)
- [Themes Trac — New Queue](#)
- [Theme Unit Test Data — GitHub](#)
- [Working with Trac](#)
- [The 5-Minute Review](#)
- [Theme Developer Handbook](#)

Section C

Block Theme Development

How to Develop a Block Theme from Scratch

What's New: Ipsum is the new default theme shipping with WordPress 7.2. Design Lead: Henrique Iamarino (@iamarinoh). Dev Leads: Maggie Cabrera (@onemaggie), Carolina Nymark (@poena). Lead Mentor: Juanfra Aldasoro (@juanfra).

What Is a Block Theme?

A Block Theme (introduced in WordPress 5.9) is a theme built entirely with HTML templates, theme.json, and block patterns — rather than PHP templates and classic hooks. It uses the Full Site Editor (FSE), allowing users to visually edit headers, footers, and any template part from within wp-admin.

Block Theme vs Classic Theme

Feature	Block Theme (WordPress 5.9+)	Classic Theme
Templates	HTML files in /templates/	PHP files (index.php, page.php)
Styling	theme.json + block styles	style.css + PHP hooks
Editor	Full Site Editor	Customizer / widget areas
Patterns	Registered block patterns	Shortcodes / PHP widgets
Required files	style.css, readme.txt, theme.json, templates/index.html	style.css, index.php, functions.php

Step 1: Required File Structure

- **style.css** — Theme header (name, author, version, license...)
- **readme.txt** — License info, contributors, changelog
- **theme.json** — Global settings and styles (colors, fonts, spacing)
- **functions.php** — (Optional) Enqueue styles, register patterns
- **templates/index.html** — Required default template

Required style.css Headers: Theme Name, Author, Description, Version, Requires at least, Tested up to, Requires PHP, License, License URI, Text Domain

Step 2: Write style.css Header

See the full example in the [Theme Developer Handbook](#).

Step 3: Create theme.json

The theme.json file controls global settings (fonts, colors, spacing) and styles applied to blocks. It replaces most of what classic themes did with CSS and PHP.

Full reference: [Introduction to theme.json](#)

Step 4: Create HTML Templates

Templates live in the /templates/ folder and are written in HTML using block markup comments (e.g. <!-- wp:post-title /-->). The only required template is index.html.

See the [Templates documentation](#) for all available blocks and structure.

Common Templates

File	Purpose	Fallback to
index.html	Required. All content fallback.	—
single.html	Single posts	index.html
page.html	Static pages	index.html
archive.html	Category/tag archives	index.html
404.html	Not found page	index.html
search.html	Search results	index.html

Step 5: Template Parts

Template parts (header, footer, sidebar) live in /parts/ and are referenced inside templates.

Reference the Ipsum repo (or TT5) for real examples: github.com/WordPress/ipsum

Step 6: Register Block Patterns

Patterns are reusable block layouts stored in /patterns/. Each pattern file starts with a PHP comment header (Title, Slug, Categories, Description). Patterns are auto-registered when placed in the /patterns/ folder.

Full guide: [Registering Patterns — Theme Developer Handbook](#)

Supported Images for Your Theme

- [WordPress Photo Directory](#) — Free photos by WordPress community contributors
- [Unsplash](#) — Free high-resolution photos (check individual licenses)
- [Pexels](#) — Free stock photos
- [Pixabay](#) — Free images and illustrations

Testing Your Block Theme

- **Theme Check Plugin:** Run it to scan for required standards.
- **WP_DEBUG:** Set to true in wp-config.php to catch PHP notices.
- **Theme Unit Test Data:** Import to test with real content edge cases.
- **Accessibility:** Test keyboard navigation, skip links, visible focus states.
- **Full Site Editor:** Open Appearance → Editor and test all templates visually.
- **Theme Sniffer:** Check PHP syntax and WordPress coding standards.

Ipsum: Contributing to the Next Default Theme (WordPress 7.2)

Ipsum is the upcoming official default theme for WordPress 7.2, currently in active development.

Ipsum Team: Henrique Iamarino (Design Lead), Maggie Cabrera & Carolina Nymark (Dev Leads), Juanfra Aldasoro (Lead Mentor). Join #themes on Slack!

How to Contribute to Ipsum

- [Official Announcement: Introducing Ipsum \(September 2026\)](#)
- [GitHub Repository: github.com/WordPress/ipsum](#)
- Join [#themes Slack channel](#)
- Browse GitHub Issues & PRs: [github.com/WordPress/ipsum](#)
- Test in Browser (No Install Needed): [WordPress Playground Demo \(Ipsum\)](#)

Learning Resources

- [Theme Developer Handbook](#)
- [Low-Code Block Theme Course — learn.wordpress.org](#)
- [Intermediate Theme Developer Course](#)
- [Theme Review Handbook](#)
- [Templates & Template Hierarchy](#)
- [Global Settings and Styles \(theme.json\)](#)

Happy contributing to WordPress!